agitators to act upon and consolidate the power gained from the political mobilisation of 1931. Sheikh Abdullah and Mirwaiz Mohammad Yusuf Shah, while still in prison, orchestrated the establishment of a political party called the Muslim Conference in 1932, which brought together all political forces that opposed the Maharaja's rule. Though the princely state of Jammu and Kashmir now had a legal and lawful political opposition, it was far from entering a perfect democratic arrangement.

Hari Singh's Dogra community and the valley's Sikh population, who had lived there from the time of Maharaja Ranjit Singh's conquest, along with the Hindu Kashmiri Pandits, stood at the receiving end of the ever-growing strength of the Maharaja's Muslim subjects. The political mobilisation of the large Muslim population had established a communal divide. The Maharaja had been outsmarted by the British, who had very deftly engineered a deepening rift in his political power and authority.

However, arising personality differences between Sheikh Abdullah and Mirwaiz Mohammad Yusuf Shah gave the Maharaja some breathing space.[16] Sheikh Abdullah, then a 29-year-old, acquired a progressively cosmopolitan outlook while studying at Aligarh. He made peace with the Maharaja and upon his release from prison in 1933, married the half-Kashmiri daughter of Harry Nedou, the extremely wealthy Croatian proprietor of a chain of hotels in the state. Already enamoured by progressive political ideas, Abdullah's outlook underwent a further change when he met Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru in 1938. Abdullah embraced the political lineage of the Congress party and began to operate the Muslim Conference as an extension of the Congress party in Jammu and Kashmir. His new and progressive ideas clashed with the ultra-conservative religious mindset of the Mirwaiz.

A Divided Muslim Opposition

A split in the Muslim Conference was inevitable given the existing differences between the two leaders. Unable to work together, they finally dissolved the Muslim Conference in 1939. In its place, Abdullah founded